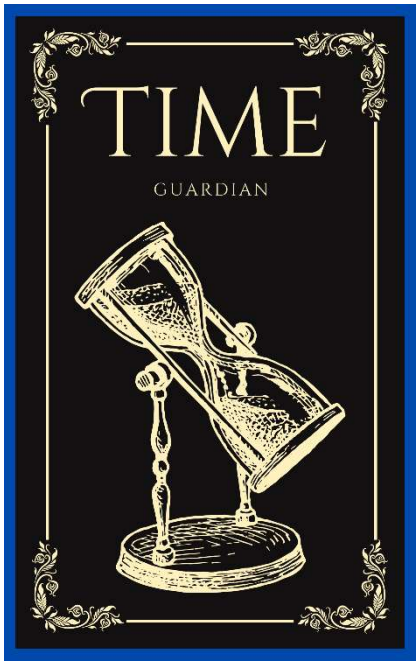
Leadership Tool: Two Critical Roles for Running Effective Meetings

Keeping a meeting on time and capturing key decisions, action items, and critical points raised is essential for ensuring productivity and accountability. When meetings stay on schedule, they respect the time of all participants, helping to maintain focus and engagement while preventing meetings from dragging on unnecessarily. This time management also allows the team to cover all agenda items efficiently, ensuring that discussions remain purposeful. Capturing key decisions and action items ensures that the outcomes of the meeting are clear and actionable, providing a concrete plan for moving forward and preventing misunderstandings. By documenting critical points, the team can refer back to important discussions, ensuring that everyone is aligned on next steps and responsibilities, ultimately improving follow-through and results.

As a leader, ensuring efficient and productive meetings requires collaboration with key roles like the ***Time Guardian*** and ***Note Taker***. The Time Guardian helps keep the meeting on track by monitoring the agenda and ensuring discussions stay within their allotted time, preventing derailments and wasted time. Empowered to gently remind participants when conversations stray, they ensure each agenda item receives proper attention, promoting focus and respect for time. Meanwhile, the Note Taker plays an essential role in documenting key decisions, action items, and critical points in an organized manner, ensuring accountability and providing a reference for the team post-meeting. Together, these roles support the leader in maintaining structure, promoting accountability, and facilitating more effective meetings for the entire team.

Use the following information to set expectations about these two roles. It may be a helpful idea to even share this information with the Time Guardian and Note Taker prior to the meeting. The following are best practices for both roles.



The Role of a Time Guardian

Meetings are an essential part of organizational life, providing a platform for decision-making, collaboration, and problem-solving. However, without careful management, meetings can easily become inefficient, wasting valuable time and resources. One solution to this issue is appointing a Time Guardian, a designated individual tasked with ensuring that meetings stay focused, on time, and productive. By taking responsibility for monitoring the agenda and keeping discussions on track, the Time Guardian helps the meeting run smoothly, maintaining the group's focus on achieving its objectives without unnecessary delays or distractions.

The role of the Time Guardian goes beyond simply watching the clock. It involves actively intervening when conversations stray off course, politely reminding participants of the meeting's goals and ensuring that every topic receives the appropriate attention within its allotted time frame. This proactive approach fosters a sense of accountability among team members and promotes a culture of discipline and respect for everyone's time. Rotating this responsibility among team members not only ensures shared ownership of the meeting's success but also helps individuals develop crucial communication and leadership skills. Through consistent time management practices, the Time Guardian plays a vital role in improving the overall effectiveness and efficiency of team meetings.

1. ***Maintaining Focus on the Agenda***: One of the key responsibilities of the Time Guardian is to keep the meeting focused on the agenda. In any meeting, it is easy for discussions to drift away from the main points or for participants to dive into unrelated topics. The Time Guardian is empowered to interject when this happens, politely reminding the team of the meeting's objectives. This helps to create a disciplined environment where participants are more conscious of sticking to the agenda, reducing the likelihood of wasted time and ensuring that key discussions receive the attention they deserve.
2. ***Empowered to Interject***: The Time Guardian is not just a passive observer but is empowered to respectfully intervene when necessary. If the conversation strays off course or if a particular topic is taking longer than planned, the Time Guardian can politely steer the group back to the agenda. This may include asking questions like, "Can we table this for another time?" or, "Are we still aligned with our meeting goals?" This approach ensures that the meeting remains productive without feeling overly controlled, as the Guardian's role is to support the flow of the meeting rather than dominate it.
3. ***Encouraging Accountability:*** Having a Time Guardian encourages accountability among meeting participants. Knowing that someone is monitoring the conversation and the clock can deter participants from monopolizing the discussion or veering off-topic. The Time Guardian acts as a gentle reminder that everyone's time is valuable, and each participant is expected to contribute constructively. This creates a sense of shared responsibility, where everyone is mindful of keeping the meeting productive and focused.
4. **Rotating the Role**: To foster a sense of collective responsibility for meeting efficiency, the role of Time Guardian should be rotated among team members. Rotating the role ensures that no single person is burdened with the task at every meeting, and it encourages all team members to actively engage with the importance of time management. This shared responsibility helps to build a culture where everyone values meeting discipline and contributes to maintaining focus, making it more likely that meetings will be run efficiently.
5. ***Developing Communication Skills***: Assigning different team members to the Time Guardian role can also be an opportunity for them to develop their communication and leadership skills. Being the Time Guardian requires tact, diplomacy, and the ability to assertively but politely guide conversations. Over time, rotating this role helps

individuals become more comfortable with speaking up in meetings, managing group dynamics, and practicing conflict resolution when discussions become contentious or unfocused.

6. ***Building a Culture of Efficiency***: Appointing a Time Guardian as a regular practice can significantly improve the overall culture of meetings within a team or organization. When meetings consistently start and end on time, stay on track, and focus on key objectives, team members feel more productive and respected. This also reduces the stress associated with back-to-back meetings and enhances overall time management. Over time, this culture of efficiency can lead to better team performance and increased morale, as participants know their time will be used wisely.
7. ***Feedback and Continuous Improvement:*** At the end of each meeting, the Time Guardian can provide feedback on how well the team adhered to the agenda and time limits. This feedback should be constructive and focused on areas for improvement. For instance, if certain agenda items consistently run over time, the team can adjust future meetings by allocating more time to those items or by managing discussions more effectively. Continuous improvement in time management will help ensure that meetings become progressively more efficient and solution-oriented over time.

The Role of a Note Keeper:

The role of a designated Note Keeper during a meeting is essential for capturing all key points, decisions, and action items accurately for future reference and accountability. Effective notetaking ensures that participants have a reliable record of what transpired, allowing for continuity and accountability. Below are the best practices and roles for an effective Note Keeper.

1. Prepare Ahead of Time: Before the meeting, it's crucial to familiarize yourself with the agenda. Reviewing the agenda allows you to anticipate important discussion points and know what needs to be captured. Additionally, you should know the participants, which involves understanding the roles and names of attendees so you can properly attribute comments and decisions to the correct individuals. Finally, organize your tools by ensuring that your laptop, tablet, or notebook is ready and functional. Being prepared ensures that you can focus entirely on notetaking during the meeting without distractions.

2. Focus on Key Information: During the meeting, the Note Keeper should prioritize capturing key decisions and action items rather than transcribing everything. Capture decisions and action items by documenting major decisions, assigned tasks, and deadlines, ensuring that each task is attributed to the correct individuals. Instead of taking down every word, summarize discussions, focusing on the "what," "why," and "how" of each conversation. Also, highlight key contributions from participants that influence decisions or shape the direction of the discussion. These practices ensure that your notes are both comprehensive and easy to understand.

3. Stay Organized: Organization is key to effective notetaking. Use bullet points or headings to structure your notes, making it easier to refer back to specific sections of the meeting later. Another effective practice is to add time stamps next to critical decisions or agenda transitions, as this helps track the flow of the meeting for future reference. Lastly, mark follow-up items clearly by bolding or underlining them to ensure deadlines, action items, and responsible parties are easily identifiable when reviewing the notes post-meeting.

Leadership Tip!

Use Technology Effectively
Make use of modern tools to enhance your note-taking process. Leverage digital tools such as Google Docs, Microsoft OneNote, or other collaborative apps for real-time note-taking and easy sharing.

4. Be Objective and Neutral: A Note Keeper must remain impartial. Avoid personal opinions or interpretations of the discussions—your role is to document facts, not influence the conversation. Additionally, record outcomes, not debates. Focus on capturing final decisions or conclusions rather than every back-and-forth discussion. This approach ensures that the notes reflect the key takeaways from the meeting without unnecessary details that may detract from the essential points.

5. Be Attentive and Listen Actively: Active listening is a vital skill for a Note Keeper. Stay engaged throughout the meeting, paying close attention to shifts in the conversation and key moments that require documentation. If any information is unclear, ask for clarification either during or after the meeting to ensure your notes are accurate. Attentive listening ensures that all critical details are captured and that the notes will be useful for future reference.

6. Review and Edit for Accuracy: After the meeting, take time to review your notes to ensure they are complete and accurate. Fill in any gaps and clarify points as needed. It's also important to correct errors, such as spelling mistakes, especially with names, action items, and deadlines. This step is crucial to maintaining the integrity of the notes and ensuring they are clear and professional when shared with the team.

7. Distribute Notes Promptly: Timeliness is important when sharing meeting notes. Send the notes quickly, ideally within 24 hours, so the information remains fresh and actionable for all participants. Include a summary at the top of the document that highlights key decisions, action items, and deadlines for easy reference. Prompt and organized distribution ensures that everyone stays aligned and can follow up on tasks in a timely manner.

In conclusion, maintaining a well-structured and timely meeting is critical to fostering productivity, accountability, and respect for participants' time. By appointing a Time Guardian to monitor the flow of discussions and a Note Taker to document key decisions and action items, leaders can ensure that meetings run efficiently and that important takeaways are captured for future reference. These roles are not just about keeping the meeting on schedule; they are about creating a collaborative environment where focus, accountability, and clarity are prioritized. With clear communication, structured time management, and organized documentation, meetings can become more effective, driving better outcomes and ensuring that all participants' contributions are valued and respected.